

- (b) Further increases in the price of food grains, which would react on other prices and would help towards inflation.
- (c) The danger that workers will leave the towns.
- (d) The harmful effect on munitions production, caused by the necessity, for example, of operators having to spend lengthy periods in food queues.

The Commander-in-Chief has given a formal intimation to the Viceroy that, in view of the risks of civil disobedience and the effect of food shortage upon the movement of labour, his considered opinion is that India's military effort over the next two years will be in serious danger unless the food problem is solved.³

It may be that if full publicity were given to the provision of shipping for grain imports of a substantial amount, it would be possible to break the market without actually importing large quantities of grains. A similar device was tried some months ago, however, and it will not be easy to bluff the cultivators on this occasion. The Government of India urge that the full amount of 500,000 tons should be programmed, on the understanding that the programme will be discontinued if the earlier imports achieve their purpose.

It is anticipated that the import of grains will not be a continuing commitment.

The India Office state that it should be realised that famine conditions are already reported as having begun to appear in some parts of India, namely, certain areas of Travancore, Cochin and Bengal. This being so, it must be apprehended that if the undertaking now asked for is not given, shipments, perhaps in larger quantities, may later become unavoidable, whatever the consequences may be elsewhere, and meanwhile the structure upon which eastern operations from India must be based will have been irreparably damaged.

3. The view was expressed by members of the Shipping Committee that the real problem in India was one of inflation, of which food hoarding and the consequent shortage were symptomatic. They were informed that plans were afoot to import gold and silver into India⁴ as a way of providing an alternative to the hoarding of grains, but the view of the Government of India was that it would be some time before the import of precious metals could produce a favourable effect upon the food situation. It was suggested by members of the Committee that, if the present difficulties were staved off now by an importation of food, they would simply reappear at a later date unless the fundamental problems were tackled, and it was pointed out that the import of bullion was only one of a number of measures for coping with inflation.

In this connexion, the India Office state that it is known that the Government of India are already coping strenuously with inflation, though full particulars

² No. 39. ³ See No. 39, para. 3.

⁴ See Vol. III, Nos. 736 and 765 and No. 32 in this volume.

are not yet available. Information has already been received to the effect that the measures which have been put into operation include credit restriction, advance collection of E.P.T. on the basis of summary provisional assessments, drastic overhaul of defence expenditure, efforts to make larger supplies of consumer goods available, and intensified savings propaganda. The effect of these measures cannot yet be ascertained. Should these and any other possible measures have the desired effect, the necessity for wheat imports might be proportionately reduced.

4. The Shipping Committee have considered in some detail what the likely repercussions would be if the Indian request were granted in part or in full. Particulars are given in the Annex to this paper of certain additional demands which have been received, subsequent to the examination of world allied requirements by the Washington Conference, for food-stuffs and fertiliser requirements in the Eastern Mediterranean and Indian Ocean Area for loading during the period August to December 1943. Urgent requests are also to be expected in the near future from Australia, New Zealand and probably South Africa for increased supplies of phosphates; these requests are likely to involve an additional demand on shipping from the Red Sea, North Africa or Florida, although shipping so employed might be utilised on the return journey from the Southern Dominions to carry wheat for India. The Committee must also emphasise that there may well be other competing demands for tonnage which have not yet been formulated.

The demands from loading areas other than Australia could, if accepted, be satisfied without undue strain, with the present disposition of tonnage. The demands from Australia, however, amount to some 117,000 tons a month—that is some 80,000 tons a month to India for six months, 10,000 tons a month to the Middle East, and 27,000 tons a month towards the requirements of Ceylon (where it will be increasingly important to maintain supplies in order to procure the maximum output of natural rubber). The Ministry of War Transport advise that, without a serious dislocation of our plans, it would not be possible to arrange additional British-controlled tonnage to lift an average of more than 30,000 tons a month from Australia, as against these total requirements of some 117,000 tons a month.

According to information supplied by the Ministry of Food, it appears that part of the difficulty might be met by shipping to India 100,000 tons of barley which is likely to become available in Iraq. The India Office anticipate that barley would be acceptable to the Government of India, but are making enquiries by telegraph on this point.

5. In considering possible means of bridging the remainder of the gap, attention was drawn to the following points—

(a) There is a possibility that the cargo available in North America during

the remainder of this year may not be sufficient to load economically all the ships which under present dispositions would become available for loading in this area, and it may be thought reasonable, if sufficient importance and urgency are attached to the Indian demand, to forgo, in order to meet the demand, some of the tonnage which would ordinarily become available for loading in North America.

- (b) It is not possible to form any reliable estimate of the effect which fulfilment of the Indian demand would have on the United Kingdom import programme for 1943, but unless there were a large increase in military requirements becoming effective in 1943, it could hardly do more than involve some degree of interference with the re-establishment of stocks in the United Kingdom contemplated by the War Cabinet when they directed an import programme of 26 million tons for 1943. Alternatively, and more probably, the arrangements for meeting the Indian requirement would compete with operational demands which have yet to be formulated.
- (c) Any interference with the loadings from Australasia for the United Kingdom import programme as at present arranged for the later months of 1943 would cause serious difficulty. Stocks of crossbred wool are being heavily drawn upon, and in the case of zinc concentrates it is necessary to lift supplies regularly, as they become available.

Conclusions.

6. Whether the Indian demand should be met, in whole or in part, is a question clearly beyond the competence of the Shipping Committee to decide. Discussion at the Committee has shown that there is a wide divergence of opinion as to the part which the import of cereals should or could play in solving the Indian economic problem.

If the decision of the War Cabinet is that part or whole of the demand should be met, shipping could be found without undue strain to the extent that—

- (a) out of the maximum of 30,000 tons a month which could be lifted from Australia, some margin might be available for India, after meeting whatever requirements for Ceylon and the Middle East might be judged to be necessary; and
- (b) barley from Iraq, up to some 100,000 tons, might be shipped against this demand.

On the best estimate that can be made, however, less than one-third of the Indian demand could be met in these ways. Consideration of the means of providing the remaining amount would necessitate a comprehensive review of requirements and tonnage prospects extending far into 1944. It would be misleading to hinge such a review on a single claim for tonnage, but the main

relevant considerations, so far as immediate shipping questions are involved, are summarised in paragraph 5.

Signed on behalf of the Committee,
HARCOURT JOHNSTONE
Chairman

Annex to No. 66

The Washington Conference examined world Allied requirements and tonnage against them for the remainder of 1943, and set out in detail the amount of tonnage required from United Kingdom and North America each month to the Eastern Mediterranean and Indian Ocean Area. Since this review was made, a number of additional demands for tonnage have been made, principally for foodstuffs and fertilisers.

A summary of the principal additional demands is set out below:—

Consuming Area.	Requirement.	Period for Loading.	Average Monthly Requirement.	Possible Source of Supply.
	Tons d.w.		Tons d.w.	
India	500,000 Wheat	Sept.–Feb.	80,000	Australia.
Middle East	150,000 Cereals	Aug.–Dec.	30,000	North America, Australia or Persian Gulf.‡
	22,500 Sugar	Aug.–Dec.	5,000	Mauritius.
	38,000* Other Foodstuffs	Aug.–Dec.	7,500	North America or South America.
	40,000* Nitrates	Aug.–Dec.	8,000	North America or Chile.
Ceylon	140,000 Cereals	Aug.–Dec.	27,000	Australia.
South Africa	120,000† Foodstuffs, Chemicals and Timber	Aug.–Dec.	24,000	South America.
	50,000† Timber	Aug.–Dec.	10,000	West Africa.

* Allowance was made in Washington for certain quantities of these commodities to be lifted in the number of sailings scheduled each month from North America and Chile. Only the additional demands not so covered are included in this summary.

† These requirements have not yet been completely examined, particularly as regards the timber and chemicals.

‡ It is understood that 20,000 tons of this requirement will be taken in the form of barley from Iraq.

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*War Cabinet Paper W.P. (43) 349**R/30/1/4: ff 130-1*

INDIA'S REQUIREMENTS OF IMPORTED FOOD GRAINS

MEMORANDUM BY THE SECRETARY OF STATE FOR INDIA

INDIA OFFICE, 31 July 1943

The Indian economy is being strained almost to breaking point by the enormous demands laid upon it in its dual rôle as a source of supplies and of men for the Army, and a base for military operations. The large sums of money which have had to be poured into the country, against which there has been no off-setting volume of imports, have created a serious inflationary situation, one of the manifestations of which is a tendency to hold commodities on the part of the millions of producers scattered all over the vast countryside. India is essentially a primitive country with only a veneer of developed finance and industry, and the administrative system, although adequate for normal requirements, is a mere skeleton. Controls of the kind which are appropriate and feasible in western countries cannot be wholly successfully reproduced there. Nevertheless, the Government of India, who are now fully alive to the dangers of the position, are tackling the problem energetically. They have already put into effect financial and fiscal measures, to some of which reference is made in paragraph 3 of the Shipping Committee's Report, and further measures are urgently under consideration.

2. Meanwhile, with reference particularly to the food position, other factors complicate the issue. There is a general sense of insecurity abroad, enhanced by memories of the civil disturbances of last year and, in the north-eastern areas in particular, by the near presence of Japanese forces. The cultivator also finds that, owing to the good prices which he can get for such produce as he markets, coupled with the extreme shortage of goods (particularly cotton piece-goods) upon which to spend his cash, there is no strong inducement to part with a considerable portion of his cereals, and he either stores them or, probably to a quite considerable extent, consumes them. Meanwhile, in order to tackle the problem of drawing out these surpluses, it is inevitable that the provincial Government machine should be employed, and here a conflict of loyalties has in the past been apparent, since the immediate interest of these Governments and of their local officers is to look after the well-being of their own people and to avoid taking measures which might prejudice law and order. To make matters worse, there has been evidence of a campaign conducted by elements hostile to the Government, designed to persuade the cultivator not to part with his produce. The Government of India are confident that under the

arrangements to which they have now come with the provinces, these difficulties will be very considerably reduced.

3. It remains the case, however, that in the immediate future, before all the measures referred to above become effective, a very critical situation will prevail, and, in my view, it is essential to tide over this period by giving the Government of India the assistance which they have requested, by way of supplies of food grains definitely assured to them and publicly announced. I regard this as essential in order that the retention of undue stocks may be discouraged; that the price and supply control which the Government of India hope to establish may be facilitated; that the sense of security of those who are now apprehensive about the position may, in so far as it has been undermined by apprehensions of food shortage, be restored; and in particular that the widespread rumours as to the effects of the large requirements of the growing armed forces in India may be countered.

4. Unless the requirements of the Government of India are substantially met, I apprehend that there is grave danger of the following consequences in the coming months:—

- (a) A marked reduction in the production of munitions and supplies in India is inevitable, with consequent detriment to the maintenance of the forces in, and drawing their supplies from, India. Moreover, the internal transportation system of India is already in a critical state owing to inadequate supplies of rolling stock and further deterioration will follow if the railway personnel go short of food. It is of vital importance that railway, port and inland water transport operatives shall be maintained in good heart and good health since the military situation in India is entirely dependent on the communications system.
- (b) It is certain that India would find it necessary to refuse all exports of food-stuffs (thus creating difficulty in regard to Ceylon and the Persian Gulf) and might even be driven to cut off supplies of piece-goods which are so essential for the Colonies and other countries to which such exports are now sent.
- (c) Famine conditions, which have indeed already begun to appear, may well spread to such considerable areas that we shall be driven before long to lay on shipping urgently and inconveniently, in order to prevent sheer starvation.
- (d) Civil disturbances must be expected to break out and it might well be necessary to divert troops to deal with the situation, thus preventing their discharging their proper functions against the Japanese.
- (e) Subversive activities among the troops in the Indian Army, which are already causing anxiety, are most likely to be successful if accompanied by reports from home that their families are starving.

5. In the light of the foregoing, I feel bound to advise my colleagues that there is, in my judgment, a most serious risk that, if we do not assist the Government of India in the way they have requested, plans for future operations based on the Indian theatre will be jeopardised, and the whole concept of India, not only as a source of supplies but also as a base for operations, may have to be reconsidered.

L. S. A.

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The Marquess of Linlithgow to Mr Amery

MSS. EUR. F. 125/12

THE VICEROY'S HOUSE, NEW DELHI, 2 August 1943

PRIVATE AND SECRET

Thank you very much for your letter of the 9th July.¹ I wholly agree as to the importance of this inflationary business, and I think you can feel satisfied that we are doing our best. I had an opportunity of dealing with it in some detail in my speech² to the two Houses today, of which I send you a copy separately, and as you will see, I took the opportunity to be as definite as possible about inflation. On a different issue, I thought it well to direct the minds of people in this country to the effect on India's position in the post-war period of becoming a creditor country. For I do not believe that they have even begun to get down to the implications of that position, and when they do get down to them and realise what is involved the shock may not be a very pleasant one.

2. I am sorry that the silver position is not more wholly encouraging than you describe in paragraph 2 of your letter. But I am sure that Kisch will do his very best for us. As for Strakosch's other suggestions, which you mention in paragraph 3 of your letter, I note that I may be hearing further from you about them.

[Para. 3, on the Secretary of State's Advisers; and para. 4, on Mr Amery's talk to the 'American Outpost' in London, omitted.]

5. Mudaliar has now arrived here. I have not seen him yet, but am asking him to come and stay in the House for a couple of days, which will give me an opportunity of rather more informal and easy discussion with him than might otherwise be the case. You will be amused by the cutting from the

¹ No. 32.

² *The Legislative Assembly Debates*, Vol. III, 1943, 2 August 1943, pp. 255-66. A copy is on L/P&J/8/512.

*Tribune*³ of which I send you a copy, and the statements in which have had pretty wide publicity! I think Laithwaite is sending a copy to Jenkins.

6. I have also been greatly interested in the note⁴ which Jenkins has been good enough to send Laithwaite of the talks in the constitutional field between yourself, Wavell and Mudaliar before the latter's departure from London; and it has been very definitely useful to me to know how his mind is moving. I need not say that I welcomed the caution displayed by the Field Marshal and yourself as to planning for constitutional reform. I wholly agree with what you said about the importance of leaving the constructive lead to private individuals. We shall no doubt, when the time comes, have to give some assistance to the politicians, if they really get beyond a certain point. What, had I still been here, I should be most anxious to avoid would have been a position in which no ideas whatever are forthcoming from the politicians, it being left to the Reforms Commissioner and the Viceroy of the day to put up the constructive ideas. The fact is that the first essential in this business, if there is to be any hope of progress at all, is agreement between the major parties and communities in relation to the division of responsibility and of the spoils at the Centre. If that agreement can once be reached, the other details will all fall into place. If it is not reached, then it is largely a waste of time endeavouring to elaborate alternative schemes or arguing about minor details. I am bound to say that I am growing extremely sceptical myself as to the prospect of any solution being reached here. But I was at pains, as you will see from my speech to the Legislature, to put it very fair and square to that body (which took it very well) that the solution of this matter was now in India's hands, and that *if India wanted a change* it was up to her to clear the ground for it. I quite deliberately used the words "if India wants a change", for the indications are to my mind growing that apart from the small coterie of ambitious politicians who would like to have the running of this country behind the protection of our bayonets, or the big industrialists who would equally like to manage it commercially in similar circumstances, there is precious little interest in any radical change in the system of government, and a fairly considerable and growing reluctance to face the chaos and misery that a termination or substantial contraction of the British connection would, in the absence of internal agreement, bring with it. It may be early days yet for Parliament to begin facing up to that position; but I shall be surprised if it is not one that we shall have to face up to in the next year or two. I should myself in those circumstances be all the more anxious to leave the burden, so far as we possibly can, of framing alternative proposals to Indians themselves, and I see no reason why we should overdo the secretariat assistance side, if secretariat assistance is to mean the provision of ideas. (The India Office will be able to tell you in that connection about the quite infructuous discussions that took place here in the Consultative

Committee in 1932.⁵ That body according to my information sat for some months at considerable expense, but originated nothing, and confined itself to criticism of proposals for which it had asked the Department). I should incidentally be wholly opposed, had I anything to do with it, to using the Federal Court in any way, or any member of it, in connection with discussion of this matter, and I shall make that clear to Mudaliar. I should be greatly surprised, too, if Spens or the Court were likely to welcome it, and I can imagine nothing more likely to compromise its position in this country, where Zafrulla at any rate is already under some political suspicion. I am myself in full agreement also with Wavell's criticism of Mudaliar's idea for a general invitation; and frankly I would myself prefer to tell the politicians that they must get together themselves. All the more so as there will almost certainly be a row straightaway about the communal and party composition of any panel which Government may propose; and, suppose we were for instance to invite Jinnah or his nominee to serve on the panel and he refused to do so, its value would be largely reduced straightaway.

7. As regards changes in the Executive Council: I can quite definitely say that there is at any rate an element in the Executive Council which is strongly in favour of the retention of Home and Finance in European hands. My own considered judgment on that matter you know, and I have already suggested to you, for your consideration and Wavell's, the desirability of reappointing Raisman and of succeeding Maxwell by Twynam.⁶ The more I think of that latter proposition the more important I feel it to be, though the decision of course will not rest with me. On the main issue of any further Indianisation, I certainly propose to make my view very clear to Winston when I get home, and I can do so with the authority of very considerable experience. Incidentally, since I last mentioned Twynam to you, I have told Maxwell in confidence that this idea had entered my mind. He welcomed it most warmly, adding that he could think of nothing that would be of greater reassurance to the stable elements in this country than that particular selection. I am very glad indeed that you took the line you did with Mudaliar in the matter.

³ Of 28 July 1943 stating: 'It is now almost settled that Sir Ramaswamy will during Viscount Wavell's Viceroyalty be invested with status and powers corresponding to those of a Deputy Viceroy'. MSS. EUR. F. 125/138.

⁴ No. 34.

⁵ On 1 December 1931, at the close of the second Round Table Conference, Mr Ramsay MacDonald announced the establishment of a small Consultative Committee which would meet in India under the chairmanship, in his own absence, of the Governor-General. The object of this Consultative Committee was to enable the British Government to maintain contact with representatives of Indian opinion and also to fill in gaps in the constitution as sketched at the Round Table Conference, whether these gaps were due to differences of opinion or to lack of time. The Consultative Committee met thirteen times in the first three months of 1932. A copy of its proceedings is on L/P&J/9/81.

⁶ See No. 53, para. 12.

8. I do not think I need comment in any great detail on the government of the Section 93 Provinces by Executive Councils. You and I have examined the arguments in that connection more than once, and the position has not changed in any way. I see no sign of any popular feeling in the Section 93 Provinces, except again on the part of a tiny political minority, against the existing arrangement. The Muslim League (unless they got a disproportionate share of the spoils) would be very likely to jib at Executive Councils, and Congress on their present programme would, of course, be eliminated altogether and that in Provinces in which in the present Legislatures they are in a majority. And there is all the business of the necessity (unless one is going to hand over the government of the Provinces to an Executive Council free from *any* Legislature) of ensuring that the government which it represents has a Legislature functioning with it. But I need not elaborate arguments with which you are so familiar.

9. I do not myself attach much importance to the matter of Bajpai's status, and agree entirely with your comment. I would only say that the change suggested by Mudaliar would constitute a disharmony so long as India remains subordinate to His Majesty's Government in foreign policy.

10. As you know, I am quite open-minded on the matter of exchanging High Commissioners between India and Canada. The difficulty, so far as my recollection goes, is that it is the Canadians who, while sympathetic in principle, have not been very anxious to play in practice!

11. I hope you will not hesitate to let Wavell see my comments. I imagine that in fact you would probably wish in the normal way now to let him see the bulk if not all of my normal weekly letters.

12. I am glad to say that as I write there seems no particular prospect of the Mahatma staging a fast for the 9th, though anything is possible between now and that date. I am so glad that you gave the very definite reply⁷ that you did to Sorensen's supplementaries. I told my Council of the receipt of Gandhi's short letter,⁸ and read out its text to them. I added that the old man was a pretty frequent correspondent with the Home Department; that I would not normally think it necessary to trouble them with the details of such correspondence save where some point of importance arose, as in the present instance. I begged them to keep its existence and the terms of the letter entirely secret (I gather this has not deterred Sultan Ahmed, if my information is correct, from passing it to, at any rate, one press correspondent!) and they readily agreed to do so. They took the letter very well, and displayed some amusement at Gandhi's tactics. There was no suggestion from any quarter (and the whole Council were present except Jogendra Singh) that anything was called for

except an acknowledgment. I did not mention to them the 120-page letter⁹ which is still being scrutinised here. To revert to the business of a fast: you will by now have had the replies¹⁰ of all Governors to my circular letter of the 15th July,¹¹ and as you will have seen there is unanimity, for practical purposes, first, that if he does fast he must be allowed to take the consequences (though Clow raises the possibility of our setting him free for the purpose of the fast in the manner that was successfully adopted last February); and secondly, that while there might be some slight tightening up of publicity arrangements as compared with those of last February, those arrangements are probably, very broadly speaking, as good as we are likely wisely to be able to adopt.

[Paras. 13 and 14, on Indian government appointments; and para. 15, on Sir S. Runganadhan's emoluments, omitted.]

16. Since I sent you at the end of March a copy of my letter to Clow of March 25th¹² about the "victimization" of the services, Iddon's letter No. S&G 1755/42¹³ of the 6th January has been received and examined. This letter enclosed a revised draft of an amendment to the Constitution Act, adding a new section after Section 93 on the lines of Section 270. This calls for no comments from this end; and I think you will agree with me that this is as far as we can profitably take the matter now. Whatever changes may occur in the Section 93 Provinces during the war, a resumption of office by Congress Ministries of the 1937-39 type does not seem likely to be one of them. After the war, the question to be settled will be the broader, and different, one of the position of the present members of the Services, at the Centre and in all the Provinces, under the post-war constitution. When that time comes, the ideas ventilated in this discussion should prove of use. Meanwhile the safety of the Services can be regarded as assured by the nature of the Governments now in existence, reinforced by such statutory protection as has been given by Section 17 of the Defence of India Act¹⁴ and the Bihar and United Provinces Indemnity Acts.¹⁵ You will have noticed that Rutherford in paragraph 4 of his letter of May 10th¹⁶ mentioned a suggestion made by some of his Indian officers that the right to retire on proportionate pension should be extended now to Indians who have been recruited to the I.C.S. and I.P. after 1924. The arguments which my Home Department stated against that proposal when it was under discussion in

⁷ *Parl. Debs.*, 5th ser., H. of C., vol. 391, 29 July 1943, cols. 1757-8.

⁸ See No. 51.

⁹ See No. 51, note 1.

¹⁰ MSS. EUR. F. 125/111.

¹¹ No. 43.

¹² Vol. III, No. 614.

¹³ L/S&G/File 132 of 1940.

¹⁴ Section 17 of the *Defence of India Act* (Act XXXV of 1939) prohibited legal proceedings against 'any person for anything which is in good faith done or intended to be done in pursuance of this Act or any rules made thereunder'.

¹⁵ Passed early in 1943 to indemnify crown servants in these Provinces for acts done to maintain or restore order.

¹⁶ MSS. EUR. F. 125/50.

1935—see the H.D. telegram No. 1795 of July 21st, 1935¹⁷—do not settle the matter in its present aspect; but you will observe that Rutherford does not press it, and after consideration I do not myself feel that in respect of this class of officers there is any need to revise the views which I stated in my letter to Clow of March 25th in respect of the more comprehensive suggestion made by him.

3 August 1943

17. I have sent off today a telegram¹⁸ about Basic English, in answer to your telegram No. 740 of July 13th,¹⁹ and I now send by this bag a copy of Sargent's note²⁰ on the subject which gives all our rather scanty information and an expression of his views. Basic English does not seem to have caught on very effectively in India.

18. I have mentioned my address to the Legislature above, and send you the text of it by this bag. On the political side it contained what I was myself disposed to think fairly robust doctrine, but rather to my surprise it appeared to go down very well and there was much more applause than one is accustomed to in the Legislature. It seemed to me desirable to set out the position in some detail on this the last occasion on which I was to address the Legislature, and also to bring out not only the thankless and continuous efforts that we have all of us made to provide these people with something which would meet their differences and difficulties, but the lack of response there has been, and the fact that the solution is really one for India herself to devise. In commenting on the note which Jenkins was kind enough to send Laithwaite on the talks with Mudaliar, I have mentioned, in paragraph 6 above, my own feeling as regards arrangements for enquiries, &c. But I shall be very surprised if the people who matter here show much sign of getting round a table or trying to do the spadework.

19. I have just had a letter from Sarat Chandra Bose,²¹ now in detention in Coonoor, and send a copy of it by this bag. It is a reasonable and well-argued letter which I must think over further, and I would not exclude the possibility that there may be a good deal of sincerity in it. But the difficulties of an interview with someone like Sarat Bose, given the delicacy of Bengal politics, and the general impression that might be caused throughout the country by such an interview, particularly when Subhas is behaving as he is, are clearly very great.

[Para. 20, on Mr H. Alexander's departure from India, omitted.]

Very sticky here—Best luck.

¹⁷ This telegram summarised provincial reactions to the proposal to grant the right of premature retirement on proportionate pension to Indian officers. It endorsed the views of the majority of Provinces that domicile was already the basis of differences in service conditions; that Indian officers serving their own country should be presumed to be able to appreciate probable changes in con-

ditions due to constitutional changes; that the danger of victimisation was exaggerated; and that the discretionary powers of the Secretary of State were adequate to meet individual cases of hardship. L/S&G/7/775.

¹⁸ No. 1636-S. MSS. EUR. F. 125/25.

¹⁹ Informing Lord Linlithgow of the establishment of a Cabinet Committee to consider the promotion of Basic English and asking for details of the extent to which it was taught in India. L/PO/10/17.

²⁰ Not printed. ²¹ No. 50.

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The Marquess of Linlithgow to Mr Amery

Telegram, MSS. EUR. F. 125/25

IMPORTANT

3 August 1943

PRIVATE AND PERSONAL

No. 1637-S. Burden which Aziz-ul-Haque is carrying at the moment, viz., Food, Industries and Civil Supplies and Commerce is so great as to be administratively unwise. He has done admirably over Food and also over cloth control. But he recognizes himself that he cannot really get hold of, or control three such heavy and active Departments at once. In the result I have decided to relieve him of Food, and to give it to Srivastava, who has accepted. Change, which has Aziz-ul-Haque's full support, will take place once long-term Food Policy Committee now sitting has presented its report, and present stage of Food planning is therefore concluded. This will probably be about middle of next month. Meanwhile nothing is being said publicly. But those concerned have all been informed here.¹

¹ Mr Amery acknowledged this tel. in his tel. 833 of 7 August. L/PO/11/5b: f 6.

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The Marquess of Linlithgow to Mr Amery

MSS. EUR. F. 125/12

THE VICEROY'S HOUSE, NEW DELHI, 4 August 1943

PRIVATE AND SECRET

Many thanks for your letter of the 15th July¹ which has just arrived. I would like again to say how grateful we all of us are to you for the trouble you have taken with Sinclair about the air journey home for my family and myself. There has been a great deal of correspondence,² both by letter and by telegram, since your present letter was written, and I will say no more at this moment.

¹ No. 46. ² See L/PO/8/8b.

2. I am very glad to read what you say in paragraph 2 of your letter about Gandhi's fast. For it is clear that your general view is in entire accord with my own and that of the Governors. We are examining at the moment various points in connection with publicity that have emerged from the replies³ (the text of all of which you have had) from the Governors; and I will see that your point is considered with the others. But I very much doubt myself, in this country and given the degree of emotional excitement which would, in the minimum of time, be engendered by a fast by Gandhi, whether we could hope to be able to hold to a weekly bulletin or even to an interval of three days. We *might* be able to; it would be unwise wholly to exclude the possibility; but, in the light of previous experience here, I am bound to say that I am very sceptical, and I think that we should probably find that on the whole less inconvenience and less fuss and bother would be caused by putting up with a daily bulletin, and at the same time cutting down comment and severely censoring outgoing messages and incoming comment, than by a lag of the nature you suggest, attractive as that idea is. I feel great sympathy, on the other hand, for your suggestion that we should try to limit the space allowed for comment.

3. I was very glad to have your support over my letter⁴ to Herbert and his troubles. I am not surprised that the Bengal picture produces the impression on you which you tell me that it does! and if you heard some of the local comment which reaches me from one source or another, your feelings would be stronger still. Much of the trouble of course is, beyond any question, due to Herbert's own personality. Our predecessors were right when they decided that for a Province like Bengal a man of real quality and experience, such as Anderson, was needed (Colville I should have thought, with his far greater Parliamentary experience and intelligence, would have handled it very well). It is quite true that at the time when these appointments were made it was very difficult to get a really good man out of the Whips. But I do hope that it may be remembered when the next vacancy occurs: for if Herbert does manage to stay the course without some disaster until the end of his normal term—and as you know I have very often had most serious doubts as to that—there will be a great deal of litter to be swept up thereafter, and a man of strong personality and much experience will be required.

4. But that is on the specific problem of Bengal; and paragraph 3 of your letter raises the wider issue of the Swiss system. I do not propose to trouble you with any elaborate comment on that in my present letter. But I would, on the two central points that you mention, say that I feel very doubtful indeed about ballot secrecy in this country, and quite certain that no oriental will accept defeat in a ballot as final: rather will he start at once to recover by intrigue, blackmail and corruption, that which he has lost in fair fight! And,